

0 TO 100 • 0 TO 100 SERIES

The Complete Beginner's Guide

Part of the 0 to 100 Series

0 to 100: Earning Money with Web Development Using AI

The Complete Beginner's Guide

Read this first

Five years ago, "learn web development" meant six months of tutorials before you could build anything someone would pay for. AI collapsed that timeline. Today, a beginner who understands *what to build* and *who to sell it to* can ship paid work in weeks — because AI writes most of the code, and you direct it.

This guide is the map. Two phases, ten stages, 0 to 100.

What this guide is NOT: a promise that you'll never need to learn anything. You'll learn constantly — but you'll learn by shipping paid projects, not by grinding courses.

PHASE 1: FOUNDATION (0 → 50)

Stage 1 (0–10): Understand the new game

The old model: learn to code → build portfolio → apply for jobs → maybe get hired.

The new model: **use AI to build small, valuable web things → sell them directly to businesses and people → get paid while you learn.**

Your money-makers as an AI-assisted beginner, ranked by ease:

Offer	Typical price	Difficulty
Landing page for a local business	\$150–500	★
Simple business website (3–5 pages)	\$300–1,000	★★
Website fix / speed-up / mobile repair	\$50–200	★★
Custom tool or calculator widget	\$200–600	★★★
Simple web app (booking, forms, dashboards)	\$500–2,000	★★★★

Notice: none of these require a computer science degree. They require you to **ship something that works and looks good.**

Action step: write down which row of that table you'll aim at first. (Recommended: landing pages. Fastest to build, easiest to sell, every business needs one.)

Stage 2 (10–20): Set up your AI-powered toolkit (all free)

1. **AI coding assistant:** ChatGPT (free tier) or Claude — your senior developer on call 24/7. Later, graduate to an AI-native editor like Cursor or Windsurf (free tiers) or free tools like VS Code + Codeium.
2. **Where the sites live (free hosting):** Netlify, Vercel, GitHub Pages, or Cloudflare Pages. All free for exactly what you'll build.
3. **No-code/low-code accelerators:** Framer or Carrd for landing pages when speed matters more than custom code.
4. **Basics you should genuinely understand (1 focused week, not 6 months):** what HTML/CSS/JavaScript each do, how a page gets from files to a live URL, how to read an error message. Free: The Odin Project (intro section) or MDN's beginner guides.

The core skill of this decade isn't writing code — it's *specifying* code. The better you describe what you want (layout, behavior, edge cases), the better the AI's output. That's a communication skill, and you can be good at it from day one.

Action step: today, ask your AI assistant to build you a one-page personal site. Deploy it to Netlify. Total cost: \$0. Time: under 2 hours. You now do something 95% of people can't.

Stage 3 (20–30): Build your proof portfolio (the spec-work sprint)

Nobody hires a developer with zero work to show. So manufacture proof:

1. Build **3 fake-client sites** in one week: a restaurant, a gym or salon, a freelancer/consultant. Real business types, invented names.
2. For each, write one paragraph: the "client's" problem, what you built, the result it's designed for (bookings, calls, sign-ups).
3. Put all three on a simple portfolio page (built the same way, of course).
4. Screenshot everything for social proof usage later.

Quality bar: mobile-friendly, loads fast, has a clear call-to-action button. Ask your AI to review its own work: "Critique this page like a \$200/hr conversion consultant."

Beginner mistake to avoid: endless polishing. Three good sites this week beat one perfect site next month.

Action step: block 3 evenings. One site per evening. Deploy all three.

Stage 4 (30–40): Package your offer

Sell a **package with a fixed price**, not "web development services."

The starter offer: "A professional one-page website for your business — live in 5 days — \$250. Includes mobile-friendly design, contact form, and one round of revisions."

Why fixed-price packages win for beginners:

- The client knows exactly what they're buying (easier yes)
- You avoid hourly-rate negotiations you'd lose
- Scope is contained — "one page, one revision round" protects you

Prepare these once, reuse forever:

1. A 5-question intake form (business name, what they do, who they serve, what action visitors should take, examples they like) — Google Forms is fine.

2. A simple agreement (deliverable, timeline, price, 50% upfront). AI can draft it; keep it to one page.
3. A delivery checklist: works on phone, form tested, fast load, favicon, live URL handed over.

Action step: write your package offer in one sentence with a price. Say it out loud. If you can't say it comfortably, you can't sell it.

Stage 5 (40–50): Get your first paying client

The uncomfortable stage, and the one that pays. Four channels, in order of speed:

1. **Warm network (fastest):** message everyone you know: "I've started building websites for small businesses — do you know anyone whose site is outdated or missing?" One degree of separation closes most first deals.
2. **Local businesses:** find 20 businesses nearby with bad or missing websites (Google Maps → check their links). Email or walk in: lead with a specific observation ("your menu is a blurry photo and doesn't load on phones") + your fixed-price offer.
3. **Marketplaces:** Fiverr and Upwork — price low initially (\$100–150) purely to bank reviews, then raise.
4. **Facebook groups / local community boards:** business owners literally post "anyone know a web person?" weekly.

The magic move for closing: build a rough homepage mockup for a specific business *before* you pitch them, and include the screenshot. "I already started — want me to finish it?" converts like nothing else, and AI makes each mockup a 30-minute job.

Realistic expectation: 20 genuine outreaches → 2–5 conversations → 1–2 clients. That's normal, not failure.

Action step: send 5 outreach messages today. Not tomorrow. Today.

PHASE 2: SCALE (50 → 100)

Stage 6 (50–60): Deliver like a pro (and mine the testimonial)

First client = your entire reputation. Overdeliver:

1. Confirm scope in writing before starting. Repeat their goals back to them.
2. Send a progress screenshot at the halfway mark — unprompted. Clients fear silence more than delays.
3. Deliver a day early if you can.
4. Include one small unrequested bonus (a Google Business profile tune-up, a favicon, a speed pass).
5. Then ask, same week: "Would you write 2–3 sentences about the experience?" and "Do you know one other business owner who needs this?"

A testimonial + a referral from every project is the compounding engine of a service business.

Action step: create your delivery checklist file now, before the first client, so delivery is calm instead of chaotic.

Stage 7 (60–70): Raise prices and tighten the niche

After 3–5 projects:

1. **Raise prices 30–50%.** Your proof justifies it. \$250 → \$400 → \$600. The clients who balk are replaced by clients who don't.
2. **Niche down:** "websites for dentists" beats "websites" — you reuse layouts, learn the industry's language, and referrals stay in-network. Pick the niche where your first clients clustered or where you have any personal edge.
3. **Templatize:** build a master template per niche. AI customizes copy and branding per client. Delivery time drops from days to hours; your effective hourly rate triples.

Beginner mistake: competing on price forever. Cheap clients are the most demanding; the market for "good and reliable" is bigger than the market for "cheapest."

Action step: write your niche statement: "I build [X] for [industry] that [outcome]."

Stage 8 (70–80): Add recurring revenue

One-off projects mean starting every month at \$0. Fix that:

1. **Care plans:** hosting + updates + small edits + monthly report for \$30–75/month. Offer it at delivery ("want me to keep this running and updated?"). 10 clients on care plans = \$300–750/month before any new sales.
2. **SEO/content add-ons:** a monthly AI-assisted blog post + Google Business updates, \$100–200/month.
3. **Upgrade cycles:** every site you built is a future redesign. Check in every 6 months.

The math that changes your life: 15 care-plan clients at \$50/mo is \$750/month of predictable income — that's rent in much of the world, from work that takes a few hours monthly.

Action step: draft your care-plan one-pager and pitch it to every past and future client.

Stage 9 (80–90): Scale delivery with AI systems

Now the constraint is your hours. Systemize:

1. **Prompt library:** save your best build/critique/copy prompts. Consistency = speed.
2. **Component library:** your best sections (heroes, pricing tables, contact blocks) become reusable blocks.
3. **Automate the boring:** intake → contract → invoice → kickoff via free tools (Google Forms + Stripe/PayPal invoicing + a Make.com free-tier automation).
4. **Productize further:** a "website in a day" premium sprint at 2× price for clients in a hurry — same template system, tighter calendar.
5. When truly full: subcontract delivery of overflow to another AI-assisted builder at 50% of the fee, keep quality control.

Action step: after your next project, spend 1 hour turning what you did into reusable assets before taking the next one.

Stage 10 (90–100): The long game

Where this compounds over 12–24 months:

- **The agency path:** niche agency, 3–5 sites/month + care plans → \$5–15k/month with systems and possibly one contractor.
- **The product path:** your niche templates become products — sell them on template marketplaces, or spin your most-requested custom tool into a tiny SaaS with AI-assisted code.
- **The hybrid (recommended):** services fund you today; every service project seeds a product asset for tomorrow.

And a truth worth internalizing: AI will keep getting better at writing code. It will not get better at **understanding a business owner's problem, earning their trust, and taking responsibility**

for the result. That's the job. The code was never the job.

Your action step for the next 24 hours: Stage 2's task. Build and deploy your first page. \$0 cost, 2 hours, and you're no longer a beginner — you're a builder.

*This guide is part of the **0 to 100 series**. The same no-fluff treatment exists for Affiliate Marketing, Content Creation, and Earning Money with AI — plus the free Selling PDFs guide that started it all. Grab the full bundle where you got this one.*